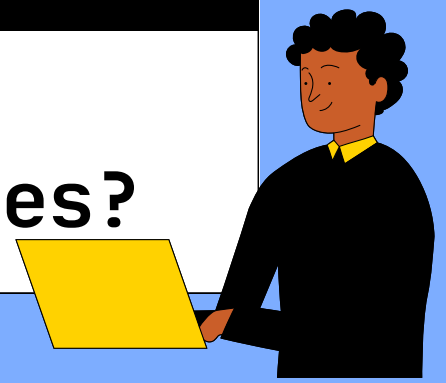


Lesson 1 – What Influences My Choices?

Analyzing influences on substance use choices.



 **In this activity, you will** explore the common messages surrounding substance use and reflect on the specific influences that impact your own decision-making process.



Understanding Influences

Every day, you make dozens of choices. Some are simple, like what to wear, while others are significant and affect your long-term health and well-being. Understanding where these choices come from is the first step toward taking control of your future.

Concept	Explanation
Internal Influence	Factors that come from within you, such as your values, goals, curiosity, and personal stress levels.
External Influence	Factors that come from the world around you, such as friends, family members, social media trends, and advertising.



Read the Following Text

Read the passage below carefully. As you read, ask yourself: **How do different sources of information change the way a person views substance use?**

The world is full of messages about health and behavior. When you scroll through social media, you might see influencers promoting vaping as a cool, harmless way to relax. At school, your friends might suggest that trying alcohol or drugs is simply a part of growing up and fitting in. These external messages are constant, and they are designed to grab your attention.

However, influences are not just external. Your internal state plays a massive role in how you process these messages. If you are feeling high levels of academic or personal stress, you might be more tempted to look for a quick escape. Curiosity is another powerful internal driver; it is natural to want to know what a forbidden experience is like. Meanwhile, family values often act as a counter-balance, providing a foundation of expectations and safety that helps you weigh the potential risks of these substances.

Recognizing these pressures is the most important skill for a healthy teen. By identifying whether a desire to act comes from a friend's pressure, a social media trend, or your own internal stress, you can pause. This pause allows you to evaluate whether a choice aligns with your personal goals or if it is just a reaction to a temporary feeling.



Answer the Questions

Use the text above to answer the following questions. **Explain** your reasoning for each.

1. Based on the text, what is the difference between an internal and an external influence?

[Write your answer here.]

2. How does social media influence a student's perception of vaping or substance use?

3. Why does the author suggest that stress might increase the temptation to use substances?

4. How can identifying the source of an influence help a person make a better health choice?

5. Which influence—friends, family, stress, social media, or curiosity—do you think is most powerful for teens today? Why?